



Zhangye Danxia

An extraordinary landscape of brightly colored sedimentary rocks and sculpted landforms in northern China



△ RAINBOW RIDGES

The rock strata of the Zhangye Danxia are predominantly reddish in color, but also include some orange, yellow, pale blue, and green-hued layers.

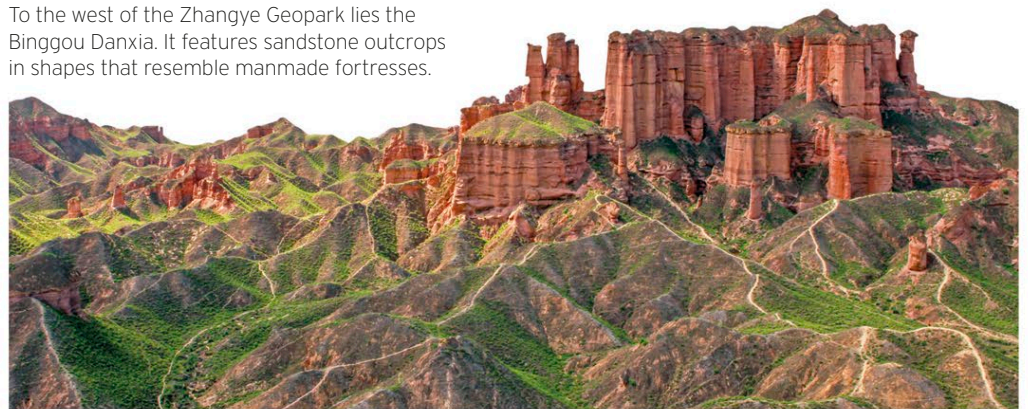
Stretching across 200 square miles (500 square km) in Gansu Province, China, the Zhangye Danxia Landform Geopark is known for the unusual colors and shapes of its sedimentary rocks. With its undulating, mainly red-hued ridges, parts of it resemble a sea of fire with rolling waves. Danxia is a broad term used to describe the types of geological formations seen in this area, and Zhangye is a city close to the park.

Source of color

From around 80 million years ago, sedimentary rocks began forming in the area through the deposition of sediments in lakes. Variations in the mineral composition of the sediments account for the range of rock colors seen today. Starting from about 20 million years ago, the whole area was uplifted and the sedimentary layers tilted as a result of tectonic stresses. Subsequently, the processes of weathering and erosion have resulted in the spectacular sights visible today.

▷ ROCK FORTRESS

To the west of the Zhangye Geopark lies the Binggou Danxia. It features sandstone outcrops in shapes that resemble manmade fortresses.



The Danxia's colored rock layers took **tens of millions** of years to form